entirety of their culture was inextricably linked to and revolved around nature, including their faith systems, sense of community, systems of production and dissemination of knowledge, and economy.[2]

For instance, the Native Americans believed that life emerged from the interior of the earth and that the earth resembled the womb of a mother in which she nurtured life.[3] Prior to the advent of the European coloniser, this belief formed the basis of fraternal relations between various tribes as well as between communities and their respective geographies. The end result or, perhaps, the objective was to preserve respect for nature and its balance. That a fraternal bond existed between diverse communities, which are often lumped together as 'indigenous peoples', is clear from the fact that when the European coloniser arrived in North America, there were close to 2,000 cultural groups that had their own lifestyles, languages, beliefs and customs. Notwithstanding territorial conflicts, which may be attributed to human nature, their coexistence has been attributed to their 'human-to-land' ethic and their belief that they were all citizens of nature.[4] This ability to think as a species that is not removed from nature, and to simultaneously preserve and celebrate the cultural diversity within, is of immense relevance to several contemporary debates where discussions around social cohesion and 'unity' are loaded with an overbearing penchant for homogenisation and standardisation.

In his book *The Spiritual Legacy of the American Indian*, Joseph Epes Brown,[5] scholar of Native American traditions, observed that despite their diversity, the Amerindian peoples lived 'a metaphysic of nature', wherein each group spelled out in great detail the roles and responsibilities of the members of the community. This enumeration of roles was based on the realisation of the 'vast web of humankind's cyclical interrelationships with the elements, the earth and all that lives upon the land'.[6] Their relationship with the earth was one of 'reciprocal appropriation', that is, to give and receive, 'in which humans participate[d] in the landscape while at the same time they incorporate[d] the landscape and its inhabitants into the most fundamental human experience and understanding'.[7] To them, nature was never meant to be isolated from humans and studied in a silo. As opposed to being an object of clinical study, it was meant to be lived with in harmony. This 'environmental morality' instilled humility and informed both inter-community relations as well as their collective relationship with nature.[8]